preponderant presence at Kandahar), despite the former's attempts to open channels with New Delhi, was unrealistic.

Differences between the Taliban and Pakistan, though not threatening to Islamabad, had existed from the very beginning as the Taliban refused to recognise the Durand Line. Just like all other Afghan governments, the Taliban began entering Pakistan's tribal agencies like Mohmand and claimed it as Afghan territory by planting their flags.[180] Raghunath, a partisan who rebuffed the Taliban, confirms that while it was in the Taliban's interest to engage with India to seek recognition, India had nothing to gain from it.[181] This is not to say that all Taliban leaders were unanimous in their intent to engage with India. When quizzed by India's Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) sleuths in 2003 after being arrested by the US, Muttawakil mentioned that the Taliban's military commander in Kandahar during the hijack, Mullah Usmani, was the ISI's liaison on the airport, and the one who was in touch with the hijackers and among the first Taliban leaders to greet Masood Azhar (along with Mullah Mansour).[182] Based on the interrogation of Muttawakil, in 2004 India 'urgently' requested access to and information on Mansour, Usmani (reportedly in US custody), and Abdul Rauf (allegedly, a key conspirator), only to be rejected by Washington. In a side-story, the US wanted to tie the investigation of IC-814 hijacking with an entirely separate 1994 kidnapping incident of US citizen Bela Nuss in Indian-administered Kashmir (for which Omar Sheikh had been arrested in India) and the subsequent kidnapping and killing of American journalist Daniel Pearl (also orchestrated by Omar Sheikh).[183]

In 2009, Muttawakil stated that the final 'deal was struck between the hijackers and the [Indian] government. The fact that the hijackers disappeared into Pakistan, well, that was not within our jurisdiction.'[184] Indian authorities never accepted this claim, and continue to believe that the Taliban, which exercised jurisdiction in Kandahar, while adopting an attitude of correct facilitators, consistently sympathised with the hijackers and proactively released the militants.[185] As Sahay puts it:

> If [the] Taliban were really interested in helping India out in securing the release of the hostages, [they] would not have parked the hijacked aircraft at a VIP location at Kandahar airport and both our aircrafts (one carrying the negotiators and the other carrying Masood Azhar etc) at the far end of the